



of the world's great cities. Various Turkic tribes then settled in the region, but a national Uzbek identity only emerged in the 20th century with the creation of Uzbekistan by the Soviet Union. The country became

independent in 1991. Its population of 25 million, of whom 70 percent are ethnically Uzbek, is the largest in Central Asia, though significant Uzbek communities also exist in Afghanistan, China, and Kazakhstan.

TEA GARDENS

Uzbeks drink green tea, served with *nan* (bread). Men gather at a *chai khana* (tea house) or tea garden where they sit on flat wooden beds covered with a thin mattress of colorful fabric. A plastic tablecloth is spread in the middle on which the tea and food is served.



SILK WEAVING

Silk thread is produced from the cocoons spun by a type of moth larva. Each cocoon is made of one continuous thread 1,000–3,000 ft (300–900 m) long that is unraveled, dyed, and then woven in a labor-intensive process. Uzbek silk production is particularly centered around the city of Margilan.



Islam forbids the depiction of God or the human form, so buildings are decorated with geometric patterns and verses from the Koran.

GUESTS OF THE GROOM

The traditional Uzbek wedding consists of three parts: the *erkak ash*, a morning ceremony open only to men (pictured below); the afternoon ceremony known as *khotin ash*, which is just for women; and the *toy*, an evening celebration for all the guests. Professional musicians and dancers often perform at these lively events, which are always attended by hundreds of guests.

THREADS OF GOLD

Embroidery is one of the most popular of the applied arts in Uzbekistan. State-sponsored handicraft schools make sure that the skills are taught to a new generation of artisans. Here a student at one school models a wedding gown richly encrusted with gold thread.

